



Partly sunny 48/41 • Tomorrow: Light rain 52/50 B6

Democracy Dies in Darkness

FRIDAY, DECEMBER 27, 2024 • \$3

IDF bombs Houthi targets in Yemen

Netanyahu vows more strikes and to ‘cut off terrorist arm’ of Iran

BY BRYAN PIETSCH, LIOR SOROKA, MISSY RYAN AND SHIRA RUBIN

Israel on Thursday launched its most extensive strikes yet targeting Houthi militants in Yemen, the military said, hitting ports and other infrastructure it accused the group of using to smuggle weapons and personnel and attack Israeli territory.

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said the campaign against the Houthis, who are allied with Iran, was “just getting started.”

“We are determined to cut off this terrorist arm of Iran’s axis of evil,” he said in a video statement. “We will persist until we get the job done.”

The strikes, which the Houthi-controlled Saba news agency said killed six people, followed a week of attacks by Houthi fighters who control swaths of the country. For more than a year, the group has fired rockets, missiles and drones at Israel in what it says are attacks in solidarity with Palestinians in Gaza.

The Yemeni fighters have also fired on commercial and military vessels in and around the Red Sea, prompting the United States and other Western nations to carry out strikes on Houthi targets. The United States has struck Houthi targets over the last year but did not actively participate in the strikes on Thursday, a U.S. military official said, speaking on the condition of anonymity to SEE ISRAEL ON A5



DMITRI LOVETSKY/AP

Mourners lay flowers Thursday at the Azerbaijan Consulate in St. Petersburg in memory of the victims of Wednesday’s Azerbaijan Airlines plane crash near Aktau, Kazakhstan. At least 38 of the 67 people on board died.

Conjecture swells in Kazakhstan jet crash

Russian officials point to weather and birds in deadly event, but others speculate a missile hit the plane

BY MARY ILYUSHINA

Authorities are investigating what caused an Azerbaijan Airlines flight to crash Wednesday in Kazakhstan, killing at least 38 people, as speculation mounts over why the plane went down.

Azerbaijan Airlines Flight J2-8243 was en route Wednesday from the Azerbaijani capital of Baku to Grozny, in Russia’s southern region of Chechnya, when it diverted and attempted an emergency landing in the Kazakh city of Aktau — some 270 miles from its initial destination, on the other side of the Caspian Sea.

There were 67 people on board, 29 of whom survived, according to Kazakh officials and Azerbaijani media reports. Most of the survivors were seated at the back of the plane, which received the least damage, according to accounts reported by Kazakh media and videos published by the country’s emergency services.

Azerbaijan, Russia and Kazakhstan have all launched criminal investigations into the crash as conflicting reports emerge as to what caused the plane to divert.

Russian officials cited bad weather and a collision with

birds as possible causes, while some aviation experts and news reports suggest that the damage to the fuselage, as seen in videos and images posted by authorities, could be the result of a surface-to-air missile impact.

Reuters, Turkey’s state-run Anadolu news agency and other outlets reported Thursday, citing anonymous Azerbaijani officials, that Azerbaijan’s preliminary findings were that Russian air defenses caused the crash. Azerbaijan has made no official confirmation of the reports, and the country’s aviation regulator and Foreign Affairs Ministry did not

respond to requests for comment.

While the Biden administration has not provided any definitive assessment of the incident, U.S. officials who spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss an evolving evaluation said that if the early indications that Russian air defenses may have hit the plane are true, it would highlight Russian recklessness in Ukraine.

Russian state agency RIA Novosti initially reported, citing Grozny airport, that during its descent, the plane was first redirected to a nearby airfield in the SEE CRASH ON A8

Tall task to call in federal workers

TRUMP WANTS THEM BACK IN THE OFFICE

But union pacts, other hurdles stand in his way

BY LISA REIN

President-elect Donald Trump warned federal employees last week that they must return to the office — or else “they’re going to be dismissed.”

The threat was the latest and loudest signal yet that Trump, his allies and Republicans in Congress are committed to ending a remote-work culture that became widespread for the civil service of 2.3 million during the coronavirus pandemic but that many conservatives now decry as an outdated taxpayer-funded perk that has hurt performance across the government.

A quick return to pre-pandemic — or even stricter — federal office policies is not likely to happen with the stroke of a presidential pen.

Trump’s expected return-to-office mandate faces furious resistance from federal employees, many of whom are covered by union agreements that guarantee work-from-home policies — including some contracts extended in recent weeks by outgoing Biden officials eager to blunt Trump’s impact on the workforce.

About 56 percent of the civil service is covered by collective bargaining contracts, many of which include provisions for telework, according to federal data and union officials. A record 10 SEE WORKERS ON A2



JEFF SWENSEN FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Mary Defrank reads a Bible in New Castle, Pa., which voted Republican for the first time since 1956.

Low-income voters put faith in Trump

BY TIM CRAIG

NEW CASTLE, PA. — Lori Mosura goes to the grocery store on a bicycle because she can’t afford to fix her Ford F-150 truck.

The single mother and her 17-year-old son live in an apartment that is so small she sleeps in the dining room. They receive \$1,200 each month in food stamps and Social Security benefits but still come up short. Mosura said she often must decide whether to buy milk or toilet paper.

It was all that penny-pinching that drove the part-time tax con-

Residents of Pa. town hope he doesn’t cut benefits that help them

sultant to abandon the Democratic Party this fall and vote for Donald Trump.

“He is more attuned to the needs of everyone instead of just the rich,” Mosura, 55, said on a recent afternoon. “I think he knows it’s the poor people that got him elected, so I think Trump is going to do more to help us.”

Trump carried the Pennsylvania city of New Castle by about

400 votes, becoming the first Republican presidential candidate to win here in nearly 70 years.

More than 1 in 4 residents live in poverty, and the median income in this former steel and railroad hub ranks as one of the lowest in Pennsylvania.

New Castle’s poorest residents weren’t alone in putting their faith in Trump. Network exit polls suggest he erased the advantage Democrats had with low-income voters across the country.

Fifty percent of voters from families with an income of less SEE NEWCASTLE ON A4

A quest for gender-affirming care

Debates over puberty blockers have left young transgender people in limbo

BY ANTHONY FAIOLA

ROME — She sat at the gate at the airport, self-consciously probing her upper lip. She had recently started waxing to hide the stubble. Nothing about puberty bothered her more than the hair.

A year earlier, she had “killed” her male birth name and entered her Rome middle school as a baggy-clothes-wearing, basketball-loving girl. But then she shot up three inches. Her voice notched down a pitch. Only a few friends at school knew her birth sex, but soon, she feared, it would be too obvious to hide. The thought of it kept her up at night, gave her stomachaches.

The distress had led 11-year-old Maria and her mother to this flight — her first out of the country. They were headed to Spain, on a quest for a puberty-blocking drug they had tried and failed to obtain in Italy.

“I’ll relax when it’s over — when I have it,” Maria said from her seat at the gate, pumping her legs with nervous energy and clinging to her mother’s arm.

There was no ban on puberty blockers in Italy. But amid a politically charged outcry, a committee appointed by the right-wing government had begun reviewing treatment guidelines for transgender youth. The primary clinic providing the drugs had come under scrutiny, resulting in what appeared to be a de facto freeze on new prescriptions.

In countries across the West, the geography of access to puber-



CLAUDIA GORI FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

An attempt to get a puberty-blocking drug that they tried and failed to obtain in Italy took Maria, 11, and her mother to Spain.

ty blockers and hormones for transgender youth has been in flux, as doctors and politicians engage in debates about science and ideology. That’s left children such as Maria in limbo, while the passage of time constrains their options.

In the United States, the American Academy of Pediatrics maintains that puberty blockers are safe, “generally reversible” and effective, tending to reduce depression and anxiety until an informed decision can be made about a more permanent transition. But the treatments have been banned or restricted in two dozen states, and the Supreme Court appears inclined to let such restrictions stand.

President-elect Donald Trump

has said he plans “to stop the chemical, physical, and emotional mutilation of our youth” with new federal action. Among those who have his ear is billionaire Elon Musk, who, when talking about his own transgender daughter, has said, “The woke mind virus killed my son.”

In Western Europe, too, the pendulum has been swinging against puberty blockers for children — though in many countries the debate is less politicized than in the United States. Britain has banned the treatments outside clinical trials, saying more research is needed on the potential benefits and harms. Denmark, France, Finland, Norway and Sweden have issued more-restrictive

SEE PUBERTY ON A7

IN THE NEWS

Hydropower project China pushes ahead with a plan to build three dams in Tibet, despite ecological and border concerns. A9

Possible challenges Rep. Abigail Spanberger (D) has trod a quiet road in the race to become the next governor of Virginia, but speed bumps may lie ahead. B1

THE NATION Texas set up billboards warning of abuse to deter migrants from entering the U.S. A3
A New York law could raise \$75 billion over 25 years from fossil fuel companies. A3

THE WORLD Ukrainian fighters spent Christmas fearing that any peace would benefit Russia. A6
Finnish authorities seized a ship after an undersea power cable to Estonia was cut. A9

THE ECONOMY The International Space Station dodged a piece of debris, the second time in six days that it has had to take evasive maneuvers. A10

OBITUARIES Manmohan Singh, 92, transformed India into an emerging power as its prime minister. B4

THE REGION A new hospital will bring the long-awaited need for comprehensive maternal medical care to Southeast. B1
A car crash in Northeast set fire to a building, leading to a partial collapse; a woman was rescued from the vehicle and hospitalized. B1

STYLE Comedian Ilana Glazer talks about friendship, motherhood and moving on from “Broad City.” C1

WEEKEND The Weekend section is taking a break this week. The section will return to the paper on Jan. 3.

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